

Communication cards

For school adults · Children aged 12 months and over

What does AAC mean?

AAC means augmentative and alternative communication: gestures, pictures, signs or devices used alongside speech or instead of speech. These cards are one possible way to support a child's communication.

1 Start with what the child already uses

Ask the teacher, family and speech and language therapist (where involved) about the child's existing words, symbols, languages and way of accessing them. Match these. A familiar photo or object may be clearer than a drawing. These optional examples are not universal symbols or an individual AAC prescription.

2 Make communication available

Keep the child's established cards and communication device available. Never replace or remove them with this pack. Show a relevant card and say the familiar word; allow time without testing or demanding a response. Notice and respond to looks, gestures, sounds and speech too. Never require a card before providing care, comfort, food, a drink or help.

3 Respond to the message

A break means a pause with an adult available, following school supervision arrangements. It does not mean leaving alone. Acknowledge Stop and Finished, and explain any immediate safety limit simply. If the child indicates pain or seems unwell, attend to their needs and follow school health procedures; do not wait for a card.

4 Print and make it familiar

Print A4 portrait, single-sided, at 100% / Actual size. An adult cuts and checks sturdy, smooth-edged cards. For younger children, use securely mounted or larger cards; avoid small loose pieces and cords. Page 2: eight messages. Page 3: optional Nappy and seven blanks. Add a familiar photo or drawing and word. Agree its meaning with the teacher and family; write it on the back, not incident details. Choose the toileting card that fits the child's routine.

Guidance checked 7 October 2026

ASHA: Augmentative and Alternative Communication
NCPMI: Tips and Ideas for Making Visuals

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Eight starter messages

Adult preparation: cut on the outer outlines. Match the child's existing communication.



Help



Break



Drink



Toilet



Hurt



Stop



More



Finished

Make it familiar

Optional Nappy card + 7 blanks. Add a familiar photo / drawing and word; agree the meaning.



Nappy

Photo / drawing

Word

Photo / drawing

Word

Photo / drawing

Word

Photo / drawing

Word

Photo / drawing

Word

Photo / drawing

Word

Photo / drawing

Word